

Course Syllabus: Writing 020

Intermediate Composition

Course Instructor: Robert Sorrells

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Class Time/Location: Tuesday & Thursday, 12:30pm-1:50pm. Room: OLMH 420

Office Hours/Location: Tuesday & Thursday, 10:30am-12:00pm. HMNSS 2306 (Make an appointment via email).

Note: These office hours may change.

Course Description:

Welcome, writers, to Writing 020! This is the second course in the Writing 10, 20, & 30 series. This course is primarily focused on introducing you to the art of argumentation. The goals of this class include (1) developing your writing ability, (2) cultivating your ability to analyze a problem and to organize an argument based upon reliable sources, and (3) persuading a skeptical reader/audience of your position. In particular, this class will teach you useful skills related to Rhetoric (such as identifying the rhetorical situation and developing an understanding of how rhetorical strategies are used to persuade you and how you can use those same tools to persuade your audiences) and information literacy (the skills to reliably and ethically use information in your own writing).

The theme of this class will revolve around the question “is the world getting better, or worse?” To aid us in answering this, we will be reading Hans Rosling’s book *Factfulness*, in which he argues the world is “bad, but getting better.” It will be our goal—as a class and individually—to determine whether we agree with Rosling’s claims and to effectively argue our perspectives.

Goals and Outcomes:

After completing English 1B, students will be able to:

- 1) Understand the rhetorical parameters of a variety of argumentative contexts.
- 2) Evaluate the effectiveness of an argument and its supporting evidence.
- 3) Construct a convincing and reasoned argument that employs a variety of rhetorical and persuasive techniques and appropriate supporting evidence drawn from academic research.

Required Texts

The St. Martin's Guide To Writing, 13th Edition

The Bedford Bookshelf; ISBN 978-1-319-53032-7: This low-cost six month ebook rental includes The St. Martin's Guide To Writing textbook. Get it through UCR's bookstore or for \$4 less directly from Bedford Bookshelf. Good news! The cost covers two quarters. If you took WRIT 010 at UCR last quarter, you will likely already have purchased this. The purchase is good for two quarters. If you are buying it this quarter for the first time, know that 1C will use this access as well.

Factfulness: Ten Reasons We're Wrong About the World--and Why Things Are Better Than You Think, Rosling, Hans: ISBN: 9781250123824

Writing Assignments

Note: For each major writing assignment, you will be required to create a Google Doc where you will draft each assignment. This document will be shared with me, giving me access to the full edit history of your draft. Essays will not be graded if I do not receive the Google Doc. In addition, we will conduct multiple peer review workshops while developing each major assignment. On these days, you will be expected to submit a draft of the essay to Canvas before class. Attending these workshops and submitting each rough draft on time is required to receive full credit on these drafts.

1. Essay 1: Arguing a Position

This essay asks you to choose a relevant and focused controversial issue that you are interested in further researching. Thus, you will compose a clear and logical research-grounded position argument essay of a minimum of 1500 words. Your goal is to write a well-supported argument that effectively responds to opposing views.

2. Essay 2: Justifying an Evaluation

This essay asks you to choose a subject such as a movie, a book, a video game, etc. to write an evaluation of. Once you have chosen your topic, you will compose criteria or standards for evaluating a subject like yours. Also, you are required to write a minimum of 1200 words. As such, your goal is to write an essay that includes outside research and examples from your subject that supports your evaluation.

3. Essay 3: Arguing for Causes and Effects

This essay asks you to identify and analyze a social/cultural trend. You are required to write an essay of a minimum of 1800 words. Your goal is to use examples from your

research and your argumentation skills in order to analyze 2 to 3 specific causes and effects which are most likely to contribute to the trend you have identified.

All of the above essays will also include an annotated bibliography the points for which are taken from the assignments overall score.

Please Note: More detailed prompts will be provided detailing the specifics for each assignment. Also, each major assignment must be completed to pass this course.

Grade Breakdown:

Essay #1: 200 points (20%)

Essay #2: 250 points (25%)

Essay #3: 300 points (30%)

Final Exam: 150 points (15%)

In-Class Work/Writing Activities: 100 points (10%)

Total: 1000points (100%)

Grade Scale to Determine Letter Grade

A 93-100%

A- 90-92.9%

B+ 87-89.9%

B 83-86.9%

B- 80-82.9%

C+ 77-79.9%

C 73-76.9%

Any Grade Lower Than 'C' Is a Failing Grade

Policies

Wellness and Wellbeing:

While I expect you to be participating fully and turning in assignments on time, I know life doesn't always permit us to focus on the priorities that we need or want to. If you're having issues that are making you fall behind, I want you to email me or come talk to me. At minimum, we need to make sure that we both understand the status of your grade and that we have a plan to get you back on track before your grade is no longer salvageable. Good communication with me is the key to your success in this class, and I am willing to do everything in my power to help you.

Counseling:

There are many events and situations that put additional stress on being a student. UCR's Counseling Center is open to students Monday through Friday from 8:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. To speak to a counselor, call (951) 827-5531 or (951) UCR-TALK. The Counseling Center is located in the north wing of the Veitch Student Center. UCR also has a center for well-being on campus called "The Well" with multiple resources for relaxation and health if you are feeling stressed during the quarter. For more information, visit <http://well.ucr.edu>. A list of additional resources will be posted to Canvas.

Gender Identity:

This course affirms people of all gender expressions and identities. If you prefer to be called a different name than is what on the class roster, please let me know. Please advise me of this preference early in the quarter, so that I may make appropriate changes to my records, and so I may call you by your preferred name and pronouns.

Attendance and Participation:

The success of this course depends on your presence and contributions and relies on you to produce knowledge through active exchange with your colleagues. This class is based on discussion, workshops, and Writing, so it is essential that you are prepared and willing to engage actively and critically. While I will certainly contribute to and help guide that exchange, you should not expect that I will lecture as a primary teaching mode. Instead, we will work together as colleagues to contribute to our learning throughout the quarter. Important: Numerous absences—even when excused and for legitimate reasons—will have an impact not only on your learning, but also your grade. Missing a noticeable amount of scheduled class meetings for a specific unit may mean your essay will receive a zero. A zero on any essay means that passing this class is not possible. Communication matters, so let me know if there are extenuating circumstances to discuss whether completing this course is possible.

Late Work: I understand that life can often throw the unexpected at us at the worst possible times. Sometimes a person gets sick, or school gets busy. I want—as much as possible—to avoid my class adding to such stressful times. With this in mind, communication is key; Let me know if and when you are struggling to keep up with the pace of the course. While I cannot promise that I will always be able to make exceptions, I am more than willing to work with you whether that be a potential extension on an essay or changing my office hours to accommodate your schedule.

Keep in mind that any late projects, that are uncommunicated, will receive a half letter grade reduction for each calendar day that it is late.

NOTE: In-class work, e.g. Peer workshops, cannot be made up or turned in late, unless an arrangement has been made.

Additionally, I hope you will understand that I am also subject to the same uncertainties of life and may need you to extend me the same understanding I will show you.

Academic Honesty (aka Plagiarism and Academic Misconduct):

Academic dishonesty includes cheating (resubmitting work already submitted for evaluation—including your own) and plagiarism (quoting or paraphrasing material without documentation and copying from other students or professionals), among others. Instances of academic dishonesty will result in a “0” for the assignments and may also include receiving a failing grade for the course and administrative action. Refer to <http://conduct.ucr.edu>. If you ever have a question about plagiarism or other academic conduct, please ask me before you turn in any work that may be problematic. If I think the assignment includes plagiarism (intentional or unwitting), I will always talk to you before taking any action, such as assigning a zero or filing a report with SCAIP. I will never simply accuse. Essays are submitted to Turnitin via eLearn, and I set up the assignment so that you see the originality report as soon as you submit your work. If you have any concerns, talk to me.

Use of AI:

Plagiarism includes, but is not limited to, using ChatGPT or other Artificial Intelligence apps, plug-ins, or programs to generate text or ideas; copying text from any source without attribution (including non-traditional sources such as Google search results, chat bots, and the like); turning in a paper you wrote for one class in another; copying from a fellow student’s paper (including their rough draft); using a paper belonging to another student; paraphrasing improperly; representing other people’s ideas as your own; representing ideas generated by Artificial Intelligence apps, plug-ins, or programs as your own; and using or buying papers from online “paper mills” or from human writers. This quarter, we will cover appropriate citation, quotation, and ways to paraphrase sources appropriately in order to avoid plagiarism. If you are still confused about what plagiarism is or how to avoid it, *please* ask me. I will help you learn how to avoid it.

Support for Students With Disabilities: It is the student’s responsibility to seek accommodations for an eligible disability in a timely manner. For information on receiving said accommodation, contact the Student Disability Resource Center (<http://rability.ucr.edu>).

Student Access Policy: Rest assured, I will make every effort to make sure each of my students has equal opportunity to participate and benefit from this class.

We all learn in different ways, and if you are concerned about any aspect of this class and how it will conflict with your impairment or way of learning, please come to me, as soon as possible, with your concerns; Together we will work to make our classroom an inclusive, barrier-free, environment for all of us.

Class Etiquette: As a class, we are a community of learners all working towards similar goals. As such, we will treat each other respectfully, remaining open to our peer’s diverse viewpoints

and experiences. **Harassment of any kind will not be tolerated.** Let's all do what we can to make the learning environment we are in a safe, beneficial, and enjoyable place for everyone.